Westbrook City Council

~ Regular Meeting ~

Date: Monday, August 3, 2026
Time: 6:00 PM
Location: Westbrook High School (Room 114), 125 Stroudwater St. (Hybrid via Zoom)
Video: https://vimeo.com/1215307757
Packet: https://www.westbrookmaine.gov/AgendaCenter/ViewFile/Agenda/_08032026-1022

Timestamps below are clickable [0:00]-style links — they jump straight to that moment in the video.

This summary highlights the meeting's key discussions and decisions, with direct quotes and timestamps for verification — it is not a substitute for watching the full meeting. *This was an unusually long meeting (just over three hours); summarization necessarily condenses and selects, especially for the extended Student Transit Pass debate. For complete context, nuance, and anything not covered here, watch the full video at the link above. (Produced by: WestbrookCurrents.com)*

Unofficial summary. *This is produced by Westbrook Currents, an independent site — not the City of Westbrook — and may contain mistakes. For the official record, see the City's approved minutes and the meeting video.*

Mayor’s Message

National Night Out, Barry Dodd Tribute, Hannaford Crosswalk Preview & Food Security Grants [1:10]

Discussion Summary

National Night Out is Tuesday, August 4, 5–7 PM at St. Anthony's Church (268 Brown St.) — free food, games, a bounce house, and an appearance by the Portland Sea Dogs' mascot, Slugger. The Facilities & Streets Committee meeting immediately following this Council meeting would take up the private-ways policy review flagged at the June 15 meeting, with a public comment opportunity there.

Mayor Morse gave an extended tribute to departing Digital Creative Services Administrator Barry Dodd (leaving after 12 years for a role with the City of Biddeford), crediting him with modernizing the City's broadcast/communications operations, including the “We Lit the City” holiday-lights video (a Silver Circle Award winner) and a U2 tribute band performance at the downtown parking garage's opening. Dodd's own farewell letter was read into the record during public comment.

The Mayor previewed Order 2026-87: a $450,000 project (seeking $225,000 in PACTS Urban Partnership Initiative funding) to add a new crosswalk and ADA improvements at the William Clark Drive/Hannaford Drive intersection, addressing a long-standing resident complaint about pedestrians getting a “walk” signal concurrent with a left-turn green arrow; Westbrook's application ranked first among the sub-region's submissions.

Applications are open for the Westbrook Food Security Grant Program ($2,500–$5,000 awards to charitable/nonprofit organizations assisting food-insecure residents), due 4 PM Friday, August 21.

Key Decisions

✓ Informational — no vote taken.

Action Items

None.

Orders of the Day — Second & Final Reading

Orders 2026-81, -82, -83 — Colonial Road Driveway, SCBA Compressor & Bucket Truck (Consent) [12:57]

Discussion Summary

All three first-read July 20, 2026: the $24,300 Colonial Road pump station driveway repair, the $107,170 Fire Department SCBA air compressor, and the $170,519.85 replacement aerial bucket truck. Resident Larry McWilliams questioned the bucket truck's cost and the rust issue on the old unit; Director Eric Dudley clarified this is a Public Services (not Fire Department) vehicle, with rust concentrated around the painted-steel storage boxes, and explained the new truck uses a gas engine rather than diesel specifically because stationary diesel "regen" cycles create toxic conditions for nearby crews. Resident Joyce Van Waltham asked about an electric alternative; staff said no electric aerial-bucket truck exists at the required power/hydraulic capacity.

Key Decisions

✓ Passed together by unanimous roll call, 7–0.

Action Items

None.

Order 2026-84: Student Transit Pass Program — Final Passage (5–2)

[22:31] This was by far the evening's dominant item, drawing dozens of speakers and roughly two and a half hours of discussion. Mayor Morse gave an extended argument for treating the program as a formal one-year pilot, citing data that roughly 56% of Westbrook's student population lives below the poverty line versus about 8% of the community overall, and stressing the pay-per-ride cost structure caps exposure at $34,000/year.

Point/Counterpoint — is the bus-pass funding separable from the Monroe Avenue route change?

Councilor Chau argued throughout that the Council was being asked to fund the pass program while a closely tied (but formally separate) Metro route change — a new Route 3 stop at Monroe Avenue and Stroudwater Street — proceeds without sufficient ridership data. He canvassed the Monroe/Glenwood neighborhood over the weekend and reported broad support for the pass itself but unease about the specific route change. City Solicitor Kevin Peronte confirmed the Council has no authority over Metro's bus routes.

> *"We're not asking to say no, no buses, no passes... We're asking, can you let us know how many kids will use this?... If it's not in the packet, we should just tell the residents it's not happening... but it's in the letter."*

— Councilor Victor Chau [43:40]

Mike Tremblay, Metro's Director of Transit Development, explained the Monroe Avenue alignment was chosen because it is the only option that gets a stop within roughly a quarter-mile of the high school without a major route deviation. Public comment ran heavily split: School Committee members, housing-sector professionals, and several residents spoke or wrote in support, citing equity and a University of Minnesota study finding free transit passes reduced unexcused absences 11.5% overall and 37.6% in a school's walk zone. Monroe/Glenwood-area residents raised a consistent set of concerns: lack of advance neighborhood notice, narrow-street traffic safety, and a shared sense the route was being finalized without ridership evidence.

> *“If you are voting not about the bus route, I would request that you make that very clear... please don't rush through this and make sure that you have the information you need.”*

— Resident Eileen Schutz (42 Monroe Ave.) [1:32:48]

Key Decisions

✗ Councilor Chau's amendment to send the Monroe Avenue route discussion to committee [2:36:37] failed, 2–5 (Chau and Rairdon in favor; McCambridge, Shaughnessy, Turcotte, Faulkingham, and Munro opposed).

✓ Order 2026-84 then passed [2:40:15] 5–2 (Chau and Rairdon opposed; all others in favor). Councilor McCambridge asked the administration to prioritize police traffic enforcement on Monroe Avenue and consider suspending the route's summer-schedule operation; Mayor Morse agreed both were reasonable.

Resolve 2026-15: Riverwalk North Trail Alignment

Garfield Street Alignment Endorsed Over Abutter Objections [2:40:41]

Found on page 67 of the packet.

Discussion Summary

Endorses extending the Riverwalk North trail from the pedestrian bridge to Garfield Street, the alignment staff and consultants recommended over an alternative extending to Mentor Street (which would require an additional 360 feet of boardwalk through more sensitive wetland). The City retains the right to extend the trail along Water Street in the future.

Abutting property owner Deborah “Jean” Bryanton (57 Dana Court) spoke at length against the project generally, citing nearly two decades of abutter opposition and raising questions about maintenance cost, trespassing, policing, lighting, winter maintenance, shoreland zoning, and wildlife impact; a letter from Sarah Hancock echoed similar long-standing concerns, including unresolved property-boundary and construction-liability questions. Countering this, letters from Garfield Street residents Allison and Dan Peterson and from longtime riverside resident Heather Chandler expressed support for the Garfield Street alignment specifically.

Key Decisions

✓ Passed by unanimous roll call, 7–0.

Action Items

None.

New Business — Orders (One Reading Required)

Order 2026-85 — Confirming Melissa Littlehale as Tax Collector [2:54:49]

Found on page 80 of the packet.

Discussion Summary

Confirms Melissa Littlehale as Tax Collector (joined the City in late June; 20+ years of accounting/finance/payroll/tax experience, previously operated her own law practice in estate planning and real

estate, JD from the University of Maine School of Law, U.S. Air Force veteran) and formally recommits outstanding tax collection duties from outgoing Interim Finance Director Laura King. A floor amendment corrected a typo in the covered tax-year range (April 1, 2020 to April 1, 2021).

Key Decisions

✓ Floor amendment passed by show of hands.

✓ Order as amended passed by unanimous roll call, 7–0.

Action Items

None.

Order 2026-86 — Criminal Forfeiture Assets [2:59:00]

Found on page 94 of the packet.

Discussion Summary

Accepts $1,225 in cash (to the Police Department's forfeiture revenue line) and a Ruger 9mm and Canik 9mm handgun (to be destroyed) forfeited from a Westbrook Aggravated Drug Trafficking investigation, per order of the Maine Attorney General's Office.

Key Decisions

✓ Passed by unanimous roll call, 7–0.

Action Items

None.

Order 2026-87 — Hannaford Drive PACTS/UPI Crosswalk Application [3:00:51]

Found on page 99 of the packet.

Discussion Summary

Endorses the City's PACTS Urban Partnership Initiative application for the Hannaford Drive crosswalk project described in the Mayor's Message. Councilor Turcotte asked whether this would eliminate the concurrent pedestrian/left-turn conflict entirely; Director Dudley explained state design rules for principal arterial highways don't allow an exclusive pedestrian phase here (unlike downtown's Bridge/Main St. intersection); a pedestrian “lead phase” was already added as an interim measure.

Key Decisions

✓ Passed 6–0 (Councilor Faulkingham recorded absent for this one roll call).

Action Items

None.

Order 2026-88 — Repealing the Local Motorized Scooter Ordinance [3:07:50]

Found on page 105 of the packet.

Discussion Summary

Repeals the City's local motorized-scooter prohibition in Chapter 310, deferring regulation and enforcement entirely to state statute, following the July 6 Public Safety Committee discussion. Councilor Turcotte asked that the City help publicize applicable state laws (minimum age 16, driver's license required), citing a similar public-education campaign in Scarborough.

Key Decisions

✓ Passed by unanimous roll call, 7–0.

Action Items

None.

New Business — Orders (First Reading, Two Readings Required)

Order 2026-89 — Replacement Pump Station Doors [3:10:48]

Found on page 108 of the packet.

Discussion Summary

Authorizes $8,033.03 for two replacement heavy metal doors (with frames, installed) at the Gray Goose and Brydon Farms pump stations, from sole-source vendor Kamco Supply Corp.

Key Decisions

✓ Passed by unanimous show of hands (first reading).

Action Items

None.

Order 2026-90 — Forestry Mulcher Rental & Vendor List Amendment [3:12:36]

Found on page 112 of the packet.

Discussion Summary

Authorizes a $7,500 rental of a forestry mulcher/excavator attachment from National Attachments Inc. of Gorham to clear vegetation along hard-to-access cross-country sewer lines, plus a related amendment adding that company to the annual vendor list.

Key Decisions

✓ Passed by unanimous show of hands (first reading).

Action Items

None.

Second Public Comment & Closing

Police Response Praise, Ward 2 Canvassing & Adjournment [3:15:03]

Discussion Summary

Councilor Turcotte described witnessing police respond to a mental-health crisis near her home over the weekend, praising the department's calm, professional handling. Councilor Chau described his weekend door-to-door canvass of Monroe Avenue residents, relaying their separate concerns about rising tax bills and hoping new rental-vehicle-registration revenue could help offset future increases. No referrals, no committee report updates, no executive session. Meeting adjourned; a Facilities & Streets Committee meeting on private roads followed immediately after (outside this pipeline's tracked scope).

Key Decisions

✓ Motion to adjourn approved by show of hands.

Action Items

None.

How this was made

This summary was produced from the meeting video (linked above, hosted on the City's Vimeo showcase). The audio was transcribed with AI-assisted speech-to-text and speaker identification. This process cross-checked names and figures against the official packet and the city council roster, attributed speakers from context (introductions, roll-call order, direct address by the presiding officer) rather than the raw diarization labels alone, and drafted this summary and the quoted excerpts. Quotes are lightly cleaned of filler words/false starts but not reworded. Review tier: Not reviewed.

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